



DEEP DIVE

How do we create psychological safety?

Psychological safety allows people to fully contribute their unique talents and perspectives. When this happens, team members can do their best work, learn and perform better, all while reducing stress.

So what does it take to create the space for teams to feel psychologically safe and do their best work? It depends on the actions each team member takes to help teammates feel comfortable speaking up and taking risks, without fearing consequences.

We can use the four actions of the REACH model to guide us. These actions build on a foundation of awareness and strong relationships.



Key takeaway

Psychological safety is built through the real actions we take together every day.

Reframing mistakes

Mistakes—and in some cases actual failure—are a necessary part of learning. The more mistakes you make, the more data and feedback you collect, the more you learn, and the more likely you are to come up with groundbreaking ideas. Yet, so often, we as people fear this kind of risk-taking. We fear that we may look incompetent or like we're not doing our job, that other people will judge us, or that we might harm the team.

What if you could reframe mistakes from being shameful or reflective of our personal character to opportunities to grow and adapt?



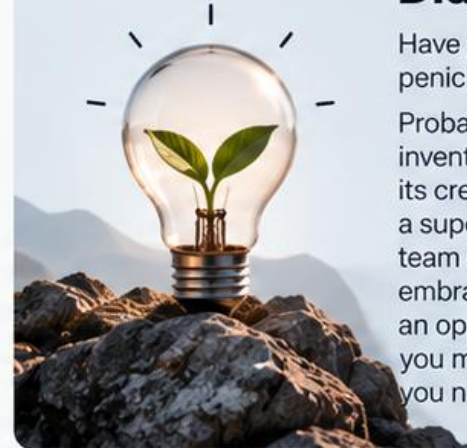
What good looks like

- Acknowledge that mistakes happen.
- Avoid showing anger when they happen.
- Help team members correct mistakes.



What great looks like

- Share your own mistakes vulnerably and often.
- Remind team members frequently that our work is complex, and that we should expect mistakes.
- Reframe mistakes as steps in a longer journey—valuable data we can work with, and an opportunity to learn.



Did you know?

Have you ever written on a Post-it note? Taken penicillin? Used a plastic bottle? Played with a Slinky? Probably. But did you know that none of these were invented on purpose? In fact, in the case of the Post-it, its creator was trying to do the exact opposite: create a super-strong adhesive. Imagine what you and your team are capable of creating if you were to truly embrace a process of discovery for what it always is: an opportunity to learn. Who knows, that next “mistake” you make might actually lead to a breakthrough you never expected.

Reframing mistakes

Read the scenario below and choose the best response that demonstrates a growth mindset.



SCENARIO

Your team is reviewing customer feedback submitted for each coworker at the end of a shift. The feedback is mixed, with most of the negative reviews pointing towards Olivia, who is visibly upset.

When asked about her reviews, Olivia talks about everything that went wrong and how she had to work outside her area of expertise and that her ideas to help her customers were not working. Olivia takes responsibility for her negative reviews and apologizes.



How would you respond?

Select the best answer and click *Submit*.

A

Thanks for acknowledging what was challenging, Olivia. I appreciate your honesty and bravery in sharing. It's really important that we all hold ourselves accountable.

B

Thanks for sharing, Olivia. I know this was challenging for all of us, and I would love for us to set up time to talk about what went well and what went wrong. There's so much to learn, not just from reflecting on what went wrong, but also what went well, and how we can apply these ideas moving forward.

C

Thanks for bringing this up, Olivia. We need to hold ourselves accountable as a team, and make sure we're clear about what went wrong so we can avoid those same mistakes in the future.

D

Olivia, thanks for bringing this up so openly. You are right that we need to hold ourselves accountable as a team. Let's take this offline so we can debrief further.

Submit Answer →

Encouraging all voices

A recent study found that the most important factor in creating psychological safety culture is **team voice—the ability of team members to give input into how the team carries out its actions.**

Unfortunately, this is not always the case. Have you ever experienced a team meeting where most of the team sat silently? Maybe they were nodding in agreement, even if they did not actually agree. Strong team voice means everyone speaks up, because they realize that their contributions will help the team and they feel that they will be listened to.

“

*Better ideas
come from more
perspectives.*



What good looks like

Everyday behaviors that help bring out all voices.



Every time there's a big decision, explicitly ask, **“Are we ready to move forward?”** and make sure everyone says “yes.”



Avoid using discrediting language when someone shares (e.g., avoid saying “yes, but ...” or “There is a lot of context you don’t know.”).



What great looks like

Going beyond to build a truly inclusive team culture.



Actively avoid the “sunflower” effect, where others align with the view of the leader.



Remind the team frequently of the power of having everyone share. In our complex world, leaders don’t have all the answers, and everyone has a unique and useful part of the answer.



Invite participation in neutral, non-threatening ways (e.g., “What could be a viewpoint we are missing?”) and pause long enough for people to speak up.



Set up formal team mechanisms to encourage sharing of ideas (e.g., have a standing “devil’s advocate meeting” to pressure-test plans and ideas).



Fill silences with questions instead of comments.



Explain why certain points of view were not incorporated into a final decision, share context, and be transparent about the decision-making process.

Encouraging all voices

Read the scenario below and choose the best answer that shows how to build a more open and inclusive dialogue within a team.



SCENARIO

Your team is discussing more efficient ways to improve shift scheduling so that each person can work the hours they want.

You have explored three potential options, and Option A seems to be the best and most innovative option to invest in.

Throughout the meeting, most people have been nodding in agreement. However, one team member, who is usually vocal, has expressed a strong opinion that this is the right decision, and that you should move forward now.



?

What might you say as you try to reach a conclusion as a team?

Select the best answer and click Submit.

A

I know this is a big decision, and I'm glad we got to discuss it. I'll follow up with each of you individually to hear your thoughts about next steps.

B

It seems like we are in agreement. Can we move forward with this idea?

C

Before we move forward, I want to know what's on your mind. Cecilia, what do you think?

D

This is a big decision. What might we be missing? What could go wrong that we should be thinking about? ☒



Correct!

You are opening the door for the full group to participate by showing a curious mindset, and using probing questions to consider alternatives and downsides. By creating the space to explore different perspectives, you are more likely to come to a better, more robust decision and get stronger buy-in from the team.

Submit Answer →

Appreciating contributions

An attitude of gratitude goes a long way toward building a psychologically safe team. However, we also need to move beyond just celebrating achievements like a great idea or finished product, and also value the many actions that contribute to the team process.

This includes valuing our mistakes, and learning from them. It includes being willing to have difficult conversations, asking hard questions, and seeking help when we need it. The more that team members feel their contributions are valued, the more likely they are to keep engaging.

“

A strong team is built when every contribution is seen, valued, and appreciated.



Recognize every contribution

Value both big achievements and small, everyday actions that move the team forward.



Learn from mistakes

See mistakes as opportunities to learn and improve together.



Have open conversations

Be willing to discuss difficult topics, ask hard questions, and challenge ideas respectfully.



Encourage help-seeking

Create a team environment where it's safe to ask for support when needed.

Appreciating contributions

Recognizing and valuing contributions—big or small—helps build a psychologically safe and motivated team. Gratitude not only makes people feel valued, but also improves well-being and performance.

Did you know?

People who consistently practice gratitude tend to be **happier and healthier**. On average, they are:



+50%
sleep
better



+33%
exercise
more often



~10%
lower systolic
blood pressure



~20%
consume less
unhealthy food



+7 years
longer
life expectancy



How can we appreciate contributions?

Here are some examples of what good and great recognition looks like in a team.



What **good** looks like

Everyday actions that show appreciation and reinforce positive behavior.

1



Proactively and frequently acknowledge the good work that team members are doing.

2



Say “thank you” when people speak up, contribute ideas, or go above and beyond the norm.



What **great** looks like

Deeper and more intentional ways to recognize contributions.

1



Make recognition part of your team’s language and norms.

2



Give special thanks to people who bring up uncomfortable, difficult issues.

3



Be specific about any action that you celebrate, and the impact it had on you or the team.

4



Acknowledge the points that others make during a meeting (e.g., “To build on Cara’s point...”)

Appreciating contributions

Recognizing and valuing contributions—both big and small—helps build a psychologically safe, motivated, and high-performing team. Gratitude not only makes people feel valued, but also improves well-being and performance.



Scenario

Two of your co-workers, Mariko and Omran, have worked hard over the past couple of weeks to brainstorm and propose suggestions to improve your store operations.

You thought both suggestions turned out fantastic, and the two co-workers both exceeded your expectations. You were initially sure your supervisor would feel the same way, but you just heard back that only Mariko's proposal was accepted.



Key takeaways



Every contribution matters

Appreciation is not only for the final outcome, but also for the process and effort.



Builds trust

Consistent recognition encourages engagement and motivation.



Drives growth

Constructive feedback and appreciation help the team continuously improve.



What would you share with your team?

Select the best answer and click *Submit*.

A

I want to congratulate both Mariko and Omran on a job well done. It is clear how hard you both worked on this, and it reflects so well on our team. I really appreciate your effort.

B

Mariko, congratulations on your suggestion. This is a great result and I am excited to see the project come to life. Omran, it's a shame your suggestion wasn't approved because I know you worked really hard. Let's learn and grow from the experience and improve for next time.

C

It is clear how hard both of you worked. You took real risks, suggested ideas we knew might be controversial, and brought creative ideas to the table. Mariko, I'm looking forward to seeing how your ideas will come to life. Omran, you did a great job discussing multiple perspectives and incorporating feedback. Although both suggestions were not both approved now, these are important contributions that will help us in the future. Thank you for your effort.



D

I am so proud of our team. Mariko, congratulations—this was an important proposal, and the fact that it's funded reflects well on all of us. Thank you for your hard work.

Submit Answer →